USER MANUAL & STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURES

Recruitment, Preboarding & Onboarding

The complete operating guide for the hiring lifecycle: job postings and the application pipeline, tiered offer approvals, the preboarding stage machine, the auto-generated onboarding checklist, and the workflow configuration that shapes them all.

3Boxes HRMS | Version 1.0

Prepared by the 3Boxes Platform Team · September 2026

Table of Contents

1. Introduction . . . 3
1.1 Purpose of This Manual . . . 3
1.2 Scope and Intended Audience . . . 3
1.3 How to Use This Manual . . . 4
2. The Talent Acquisition Lifecycle . . . 4
2.1 Where Each Module Ends and the Next Begins . . . 4
2.2 The Golden Thread: Configuration . . . 5
3. Recruitment Module . . . 5
3.1 Module Workflow . . . 5
3.2 The Recruitment Dashboard . . . 6
3.3 Job Postings: Creating and Managing . . . 7
3.4 Screening Tools and Analytics . . . 8
3.5 Offers and the Tiered Approval Chain . . . 8
3.6 Reading the Funnel Signals . . . 9
4. Preboarding Module . . . 10
4.1 Module Workflow: The Stage Machine . . . 10
4.2 The Preboarding Screen . . . 11
4.3 Documents and Background Verification . . . 12
5. Onboarding Module . . . 12
5.1 Module Workflow: The Conversion Cascade . . . 12
5.2 The Onboarding Screen . . . 13
5.3 Creating and Editing Tasks Manually . . . 14
5.4 Task Templates and the Precedence Rule . . . 15
6. Workflow Configuration (Admin Guide) . . . 15
6.1 Access and How Configuration Resolves . . . 16
6.2 Tab 1: Recruitment Pipeline and Offer Approval Chain . . . 16
6.3 Tab 2: Preboarding Stages . . . 17
6.4 Tab 3: Onboarding Checklist . . . 18
6.5 Saving, Resetting and Safe Experimentation . . . 18
7. Roles and Permissions . . . 19
8. Approval and Permission Matrix . . . 20

9. Role Quick-Reference Cards 21
9.1 HR Administrator 21
9.2 Recruiter / Hiring Manager 21
9.3 Approver (Tier signatory) 21
9.4 IT / Admin / Finance support functions 21
10. FAQ and Troubleshooting 22
10.1 Why is my offer stuck at "Pending Approval"? 22
10.2 Who can approve if no tiers are configured? 22
10.3 Can I rename or add pipeline stages? 22
10.4 Why can't I set a preboarding candidate to a stage I removed? 22
10.5 A converted candidate has no onboarding tasks - why? 22
10.6 Where do due dates on generated tasks come from? 23
10.7 What does an SLA number on a stage actually do? 23
10.8 Why does the pipeline chart show my custom stage names? 23
10.9 Can two candidates share one preboarding stage order differently? 23
10.10 What happens to the job's vacancy count after conversion? 23
10.11 A candidate declined after preboarding started - now what? 23
10.12 Who receives preboarding stage notifications? 23
11. Glossary 24

1. Introduction

This manual is the standard operating procedure (SOP) and user guide for the three talent-acquisition modules of 3Boxes HRMS: **Recruitment**, **Preboarding** and **Onboarding**. Together these modules carry a new hire from the first job requisition to a fully productive employee, and every step in between is configurable by your own administrators. The manual documents the workflows exactly as they are implemented in the product, including the field names, buttons, page paths and approval rules that users will see on screen.

A deliberate design principle of this suite is that **workflow logic lives in configuration, not in code**. Pipeline stage names, service-level targets, approval tiers, preboarding stages and the auto-generated onboarding checklist are all maintained by HR administrators through the Workflow Configuration editor. This manual therefore gives workflow configuration its own dedicated chapter (Chapter 6), and every module chapter explains which configuration drives the behaviour being described. If a screen in your tenant shows different stage labels than the examples in this manual, the underlying workflow is the same - only the configured labels differ.

1.1 Purpose of This Manual

The purpose of this document is to let every role - HR administrator, recruiter, hiring manager, approver and new hire support functions such as IT - operate the hiring lifecycle confidently and consistently. It provides step-by-step procedures for daily tasks, explains the approval and gating rules that the system enforces automatically, and serves as the reference for troubleshooting the questions that most often reach the help desk. Following the SOP ensures that data stays consistent across the three modules and that candidates receive a professional, trackable experience from application to their first completed week.

1.2 Scope and Intended Audience

The manual covers the Recruitment module (requisitions, job postings, applications, screening, interviews, offers and the tiered offer approval chain), the Preboarding module (the stage machine that runs from offer acceptance to Day 1 readiness, including document collection and background verification tracking), and the Onboarding module (checklists, task templates and progress tracking). It also covers the Workflow Configuration editor that administers all three. Out of scope are the Performance, Project Management and Attendance modules, which are documented separately; where those modules interact with hiring (for example the employee record created on conversion), the interaction is described from the hiring side only.

Readers are assumed to have a working 3Boxes HRMS account with one of the standard roles. Chapter 7 defines what each role can see and do, and Chapter 8 provides the action-by-action permission matrix. Screenshots in this manual were taken from a live demo tenant; your data will naturally differ, but the layout and controls are identical.

1.3 How to Use This Manual

Chapters are organised **module by module** as requested by operating teams: each module chapter opens with a workflow diagram, walks through the screen regions in the order a user encounters them, and then presents numbered SOP procedures for the core tasks. Numbered steps are meant to be followed top to bottom the first few times; after that, the quick-reference cards in Chapter 9 are designed for daily use. Administrators configuring the system for the first time should read Chapter 2 for the big picture, then work through Chapter 6 carefully before going live, because configuration changes apply to the whole tenant immediately.

2. The Talent Acquisition Lifecycle

The three modules form one continuous pipeline with clear hand-offs. Recruitment owns everything up to a hired, offer-accepted candidate. The **conversion cascade** is the bridge: a single click turns the accepted offer into an employee record, starts preboarding, and generates the onboarding checklist. Preboarding then prepares everything physically and legally required before the joining date, and Onboarding runs the first 30 days of structured integration. Understanding these boundaries is the fastest way to answer the classic question of where a person "is" in the system at any moment.

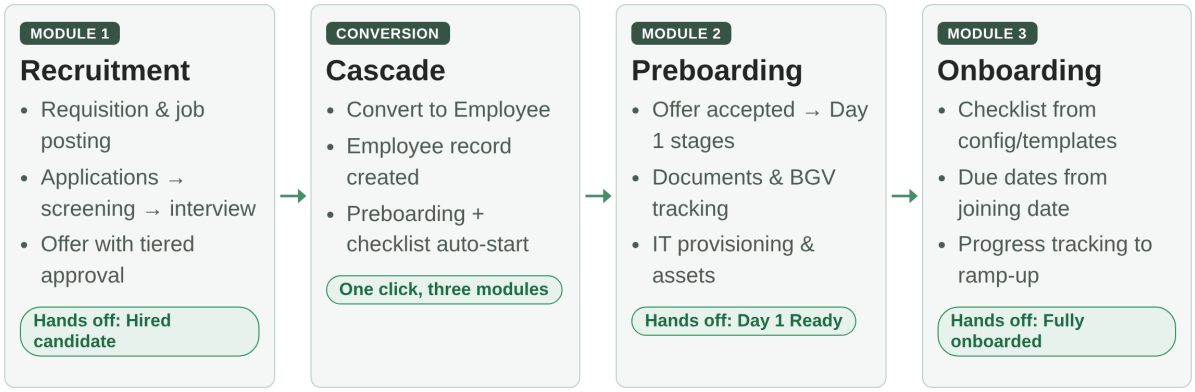


Figure 2-1: The end-to-end talent acquisition lifecycle across the three modules, with the conversion cascade as the bridge.

Each module hands off a well-defined artefact. Recruitment hands off a **hired candidate with an accepted offer**. The cascade hands off an **employee record plus a preboarding case plus a generated checklist**. Preboarding hands off a **Day 1 Ready employee with verified documents and completed background verification**. Onboarding hands off a **fully onboarded employee** whose tasks, training and allocations are complete. Because every hand-off is logged and auditable, HR can always reconstruct who did what and when.

2.1 Where Each Module Ends and the Next Begins

Boundary	Trigger	What the receiving module gets
Recruitment to cascade	User clicks Convert on an accepted offer (Offer Management)	Employee record (probation status), preboarding case at the first enabled stage, generated onboarding tasks, notifications to HR, IT, Admin and Finance
Preboarding to Day 1	Candidate reaches the final configured stage (Day 1 Ready / Joined) and passes the enabled gates	A joining-ready employee; onboarding checklist tasks due before Day 1 should already be complete
Onboarding completion	All checklist tasks completed or skipped	Employee marked fully onboarded in the Onboarding Progress panel

Table 2-1: Module boundaries and hand-off artefacts.

2.2 The Golden Thread: Configuration

One configuration page drives all three modules. The stage names you see on the recruitment pipeline, the number of approval tiers an offer passes through, the preboarding ladder, the HR-verification and document gates, and the checklist a new hire receives are all read live from the tenant's workflow configuration. This is why the dashboard pipeline chart, the preboarding stage ladder and the conversion checklist always agree with each other: they are three views of the same source of truth. Chapter 6 explains every field of that editor, and the module chapters cross-reference the relevant section wherever configuration changes behaviour.

3. Recruitment Module

The Recruitment module is a full applicant tracking system (ATS): requisitions and job postings at the top of the funnel, application intake and screening in the middle, interviews and offers near the bottom, and a tiered approval chain guarding every offer. The primary working page is **/recruitment**, with three tabs - Jobs, Candidates and Analytics - while the **/dashboards/recruitment** page provides the management view of funnel health. Offers live on their own **/offers** page, because their approval workflow deserves dedicated space.

```
Navigation: Sidebar: Recruitment > Recruitment Dashboard (/dashboards/recruitment),
Requisitions (/requisitions), Offers (/offers), Workflow Configuration
(/recruitment/workflow-config)
```

3.1 Module Workflow

The application pipeline has six fixed stages: applied, screening, interview, offered, hired and rejected. The **keys are fixed by the system** because they are stored on every application record, but their display labels, order, SLA targets, colours and visibility are configurable per tenant. When an application reaches the Offered stage, an offer record is created on the Offers page and must pass the configured approval chain tier by tier before it can be sent to the candidate. Only after the candidate accepts can the recruiter convert the

offer into an employee, which triggers the cascade described in Chapter 5.

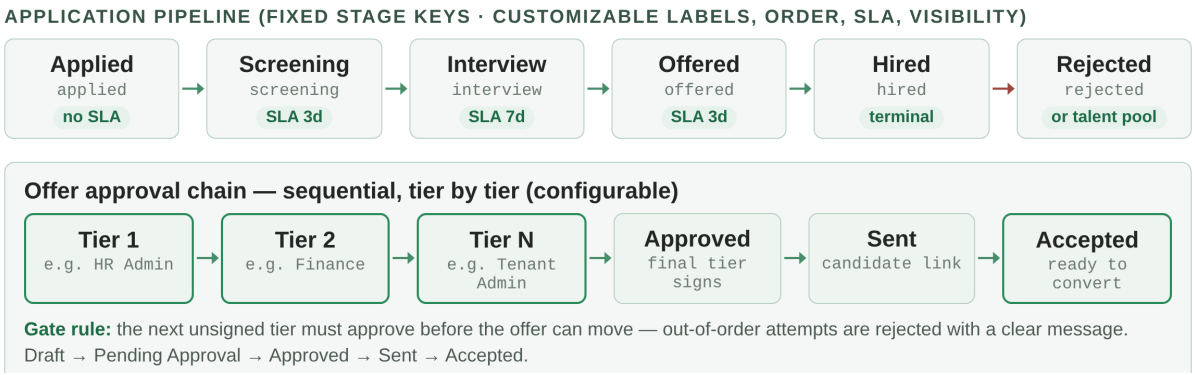


Figure 3-1: Recruitment module workflow - the six-stage application pipeline and the sequential offer approval chain.

3.2 The Recruitment Dashboard

```
Navigation: Recruitment > Recruitment Dashboard (/dashboards/recruitment)
```

The dashboard is the morning checkpoint for the hiring team. Six stat cards summarise the funnel: **Open Positions**, **Total Applications**, **Interviews Scheduled**, **Offers Pending**, **Hires This Month** and **Avg Time-to-Hire** (in days). All values are computed live from the tenant database - there are no demo or cached numbers. The **Recruitment Pipeline** bar chart below the cards is built from the configured workflow stages, so it shows your own stage labels and includes a conversion percentage under each bar. A **Source Distribution** donut shows which channels (LinkedIn, referrals, job portals and so on) feed the funnel, alongside a monthly applications trend, recent applications and upcoming interviews.

The Quick Actions strip links to the six most frequent tasks: Post New Job, Schedule Interview, Review Applications, Talent Pool, Offer Management and Analytics. Note that because the pipeline chart reads the live configuration, renaming a stage in Workflow Configuration (Chapter 6.2) changes the chart immediately - a useful way to verify that a configuration change has taken effect.

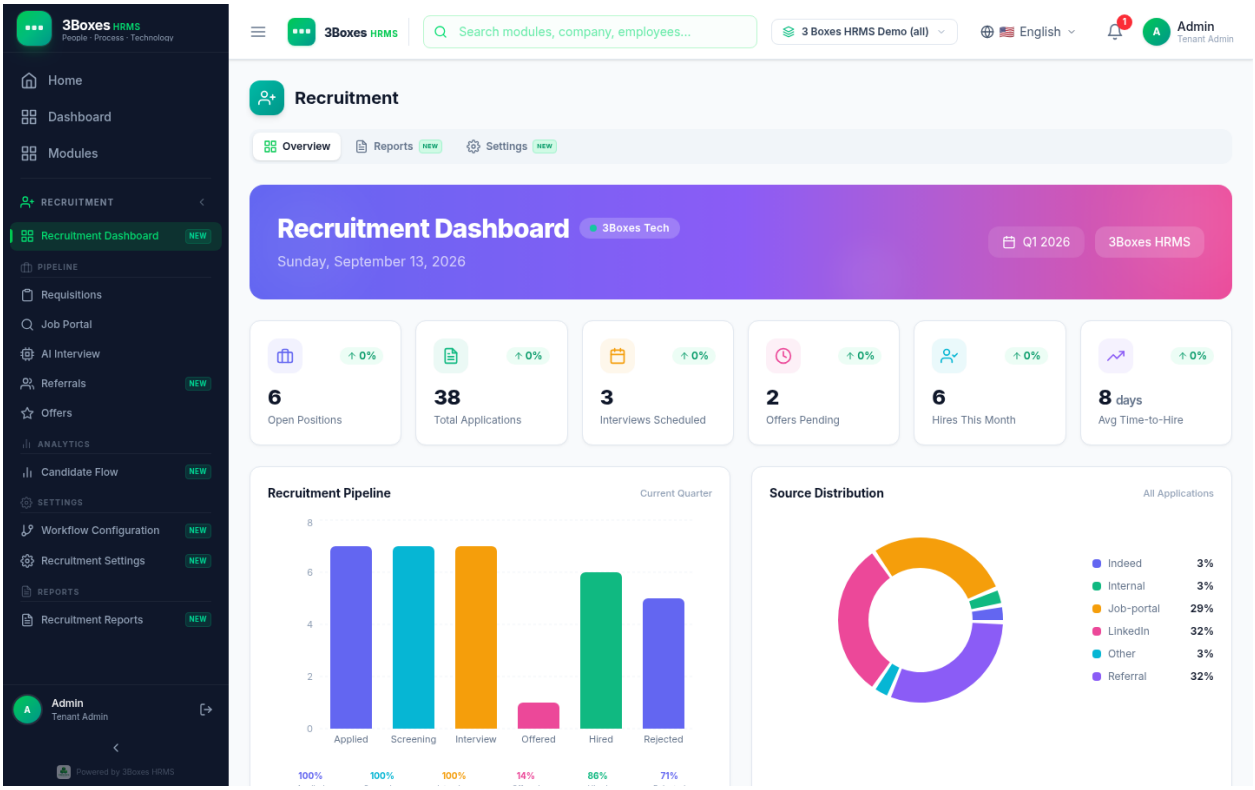


Figure 3-2: Recruitment Dashboard with live stats and the configured pipeline chart.

3.3 Job Postings: Creating and Managing

```
Navigation: Recruitment > (working page) /recruitment > Jobs tab > Create Job
```

Job postings are the containers for openings. The Jobs tab lists every posting with search and filters for type (Full-time, Part-time, Contract, Internship), status (Open, Closed, On Hold, Filled) and department. Each row expands to show its applicants with inline status editing. Best practice, reflected in the module's own tips, is to create the requisition first on the Requisitions page and then raise the posting against it, so that approvals and headcount stay linked.

SOP - Post a new job

1. Open **/recruitment** and stay on the **Jobs** tab.
2. Click **Create Job** (top right; visible to admin roles).
3. Fill the required fields: **Job Title**, **Department** and **Description**; optionally Position, Location, Type, Experience, Salary Range, Vacancies, Closing Date and Requirements.
4. Click **Post Job**. The posting appears in the list with status Open.
5. To share externally, use the job board chips on the posting's detail page (LinkedIn, Indeed, Glassdoor, StepStone, Naukri) or point candidates to the public careers site at /careers.

SOP - Move an application through the pipeline

1. Open the job's detail page (click a posting) and switch to the **Pipeline** tab, or work from the **Candidates** tab of /recruitment.
2. Set the application status using the status editor (Applied, Screening, Interview, Offered, Hired, Rejected) and click **Save**.
3. Strong but unmatched candidates can be moved to the talent pool with **Move to Talent Pool** instead of being rejected outright.
4. The SLA badges configured per stage (for example Screening 3d, Interview 7d) are your service targets; the dashboard trend helps you spot stages that routinely breach them.

> **Privacy note**
>
> Non-recruiter users see candidate contact details masked with a "PII masked for hiring panel" badge. The masking policy is configurable by admins under /recruitment/pii-policy.

3.4 Screening Tools and Analytics

The **Analytics** tab of /recruitment is a cross-application shortlist finder. Enter skills (comma separated), experience range in years, expected salary range, status and optionally a specific job posting, then click **Search Candidates**. The results panel reports Total Matches, Average Experience, Average Expected Salary and Unique Skills Found, and renders a clickable skills cloud - clicking a skill filters the result set further. This is the fastest way to build a shortlist from the full historical applicant pool rather than from a single posting.

The module also ships AI-assisted helpers: resume parsing and consent capture under /api/ats, and a sentiment analysis action on candidate cards. These are aids to human decision-making; the pipeline status always remains a manual, auditable decision.

3.5 Offers and the Tiered Approval Chain

```
Navigation: Recruitment > Offers (/offers)
```

Every offer is created on the Offers page and carries a status: draft, pending_approval, approved, sent, accepted, rejected or withdrawn. The **Workflow** column of the offer table is where the lifecycle happens: clicking **Advance** moves the offer to the next status. While approval tiers remain unsigned the offer sits at **pending_approval** and each qualifying click records one tier approval. The system enforces **strict tier order**: the API checks the next unsigned tier and, if the current user does not match it, rejects the action with HTTP 403 and the message "Approval blocked: tier {n} of {total} requires \"{label}\" to approve before you can act." The signed tiers are stored on the offer as an approval trail.

Once the final tier signs, the status flips to **approved**; the next Advance sends the offer and mints a secure candidate link (an access token) that can be copied with the **Link** button. The candidate opens the link, reviews the offer and accepts or declines; a declined offer optionally routes the candidate to a decline survey. An **accepted** offer shows the **Convert** button - the doorway to the onboarding cascade (Chapter 5). If no approval tiers are configured, only admin-level roles may approve offers, preserving a single controlled

signature.

SOP - Create and route an offer

1. On **/offers** click **Create Offer**.
2. Fill **Candidate Name**, **Position**, **Salary** and **Joining Date** (required), plus email, department, currency (INR/USD/EUR) and probation days as needed.
3. Click **Create**. The offer starts as **draft**.
4. Click **Advance** to submit it - status becomes **pending_approval**.
5. Each configured approver (tier) clicks **Advance** in order; each click records one tier signature. The badge stays "Pending Approval" until the final tier signs.
6. When the offer shows **approved**, click **Advance** again to **send** it, then use **Link** to copy the candidate link and share it.
7. When the candidate accepts (status **accepted**), click **Convert** to start the onboarding cascade.

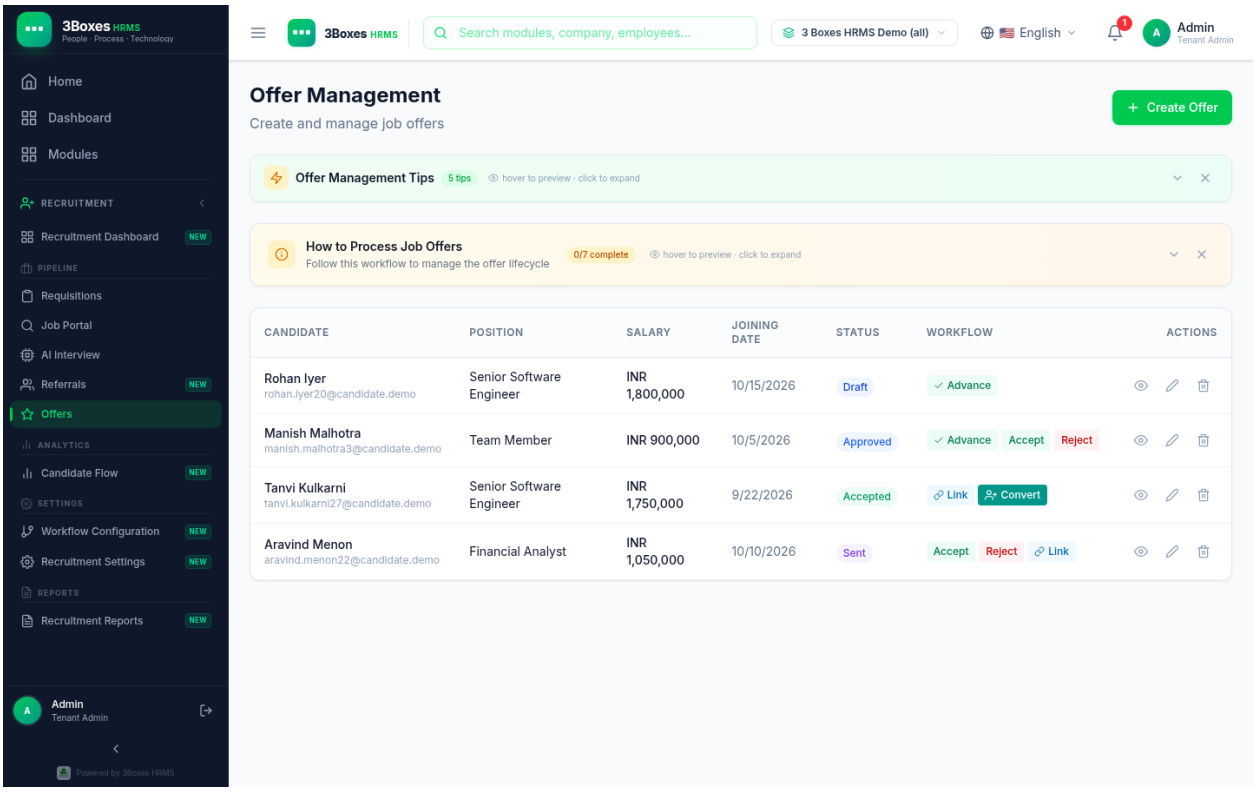


Figure 3-3: Offer Management - the Workflow column drives Advance, Link and Convert actions.

3.6 Reading the Funnel Signals

Three signals on the dashboard deserve a daily glance. First, **Offers Pending** greater than zero for more than a day usually means a tier approver has not acted - the approval trail on the offer tells you exactly which tier is waiting. Second, a **conversion percentage** below roughly 10% between Screening and Interview often indicates the screening criteria are stricter than the job requirements. Third, **Avg Time-to-Hire** trending upward while applications stay flat suggests an SLA breach somewhere in the middle of the pipeline;

compare the per-stage SLA targets in Workflow Configuration with the actual stage ages to find the bottleneck.

4. Preboarding Module

Preboarding is the stage machine that runs between "offer accepted" and "ready for Day 1". It exists because the weeks between acceptance and joining are where offers are lost and Day 1 failures are created: documents do not arrive, background checks stall, laptops are not ordered. The module makes this invisible work visible as a ladder of six configurable stages, each with its own SLA target and responsible role, and each advancing the candidate one concrete step closer to joining.

```
Navigation: Sidebar: Preboarding > Preboarding Dashboard (/preboarding)
```

4.1 Module Workflow: The Stage Machine

A converted candidate enters preboarding at the **first enabled stage after offer acceptance** - by default Document Collection - and advances forward one stage at a time. The default ladder is **Offer Accepted (2d)**, **Document Collection (5d)**, **Background Verification (7d)**, **IT Provisioning (3d)**, **Asset Request (2d)** and **Day 1 Ready / Joined**. Each stage carries an SLA in days and a notify-roles list; when a candidate enters a stage, the configured roles receive a notification. Disabled stages are hidden everywhere and cannot be set - the API rejects transitions into them with a validation error, so the ladder can be shortened per tenant without breaking the flow.

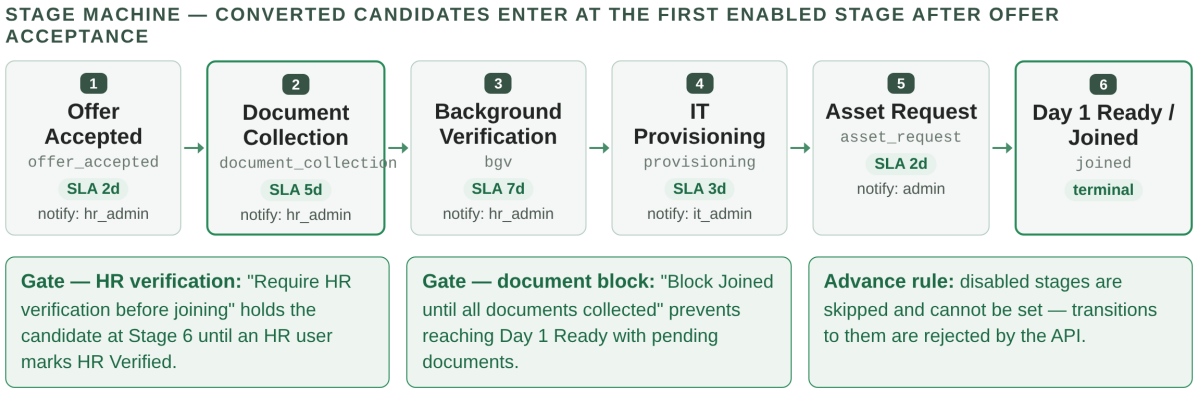


Figure 4-1: The preboarding stage machine with default SLAs, notify roles and the two joining gates.

Two optional gates harden the end of the ladder. **Require HR verification before joining** holds the candidate at the final stage until an HR user confirms the HR Verified toggle. **Block "Joined" until all documents are collected** prevents reaching Day 1 Ready with pending documents - the classic protection against "we will get the contract signed later". Both are checkboxes in the Preboarding Stages tab of Workflow Configuration (Chapter 6.3).

4.2 The Preboarding Screen

```
Navigation: Preboarding > /preboarding > Pipeline tab
```

The dashboard opens with four stat cards - **Total Candidates**, **In Progress**, **Pending BGV** and **Ready for Day 1** - followed by the stage ladder bar that mirrors your configured stages with live counts. Below it, the **Pipeline** table lists candidates with their position, current stage, start date and HR Verified state. The **Documents** tab tracks per-candidate document status (Pending, Uploaded, Verified, Rejected) across the standard document set, and the **BGV Tracking** tab records vendor background-check status (Pending, In Progress, Completed, Failed) with submission and completion dates. A live-data banner shows whether candidates have been converted from recruitment yet.

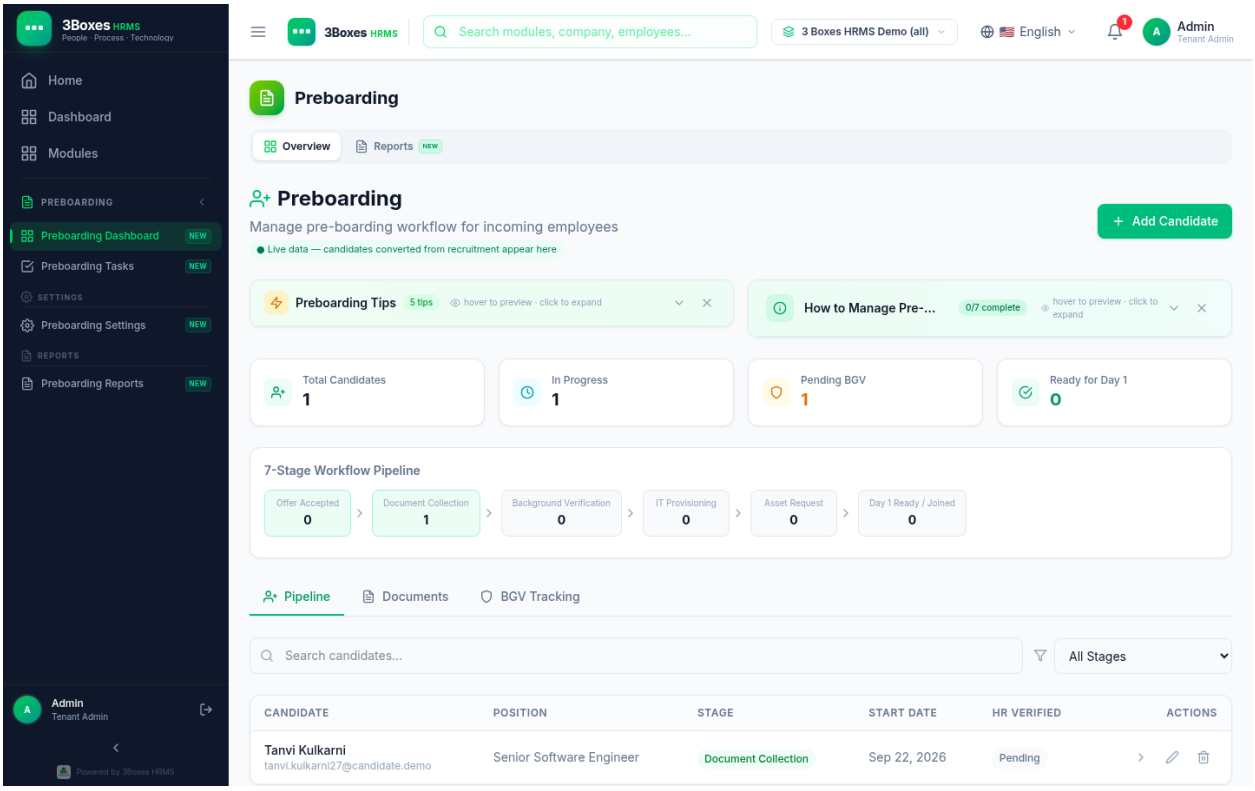


Figure 4-2: Preboarding dashboard - stat cards, the configured stage ladder and the candidate pipeline.

SOP - Advance a candidate through preboarding

1. Open **/preboarding** and locate the candidate in the Pipeline table (use the search box or the All Stages filter).
2. Complete the work of the current stage first - upload and verify documents in the Documents tab, or update the BGV record in BGV Tracking.
3. Click **Advance Stage** (chevron) in the Actions column. The candidate moves to the next enabled stage and the notify roles of that stage are informed.
4. If the candidate cannot proceed (for example BGV failed), edit the candidate and set the stage back, or use Cancelled - stage moves are auditable.

5. Before the final stage, confirm the enabled gates: HR Verified must be marked if that gate is on, and all documents must be verified if the document block is on.

> **UI behaviour**
>
> The Advance action is optimistic: the row updates immediately and rolls back automatically if the server rejects the transition, for example into a disabled stage.

4.3 Documents and Background Verification

The Documents tab presents one grid per candidate covering the standard document set: offer letter, ID proof, tax forms, direct deposit details, employment agreement and emergency contact. Each document moves through Pending, Uploaded, Verified and Rejected; HR should verify only originals or registry-checked copies, because the document gate trusts these statuses when it blocks or allows joining. The BGV Tracking tab is deliberately minimal: vendor, status, submitted and completed dates and free notes, which is enough to keep the background-check vendor accountable against the stage SLA without duplicating the vendor's own portal.

Candidates can also be added manually with **Add Candidate** (Full Name, Email, Position, Stage, Start Date) for cases that bypass recruitment, such as rehires or intern conversions handled offline. The stage select in that form lists exactly the enabled stages from configuration, so manually added candidates follow the same ladder as converted ones.

5. Onboarding Module

Onboarding turns a joining-ready candidate into a productive employee through a structured checklist. Its distinguishing feature is that **the checklist creates itself**: when an accepted offer is converted, the system generates the right tasks for that hire with due dates computed from the joining date, assigns them categories and owners, and notifies the responsible functions. HR then tracks completion on a single page with per-employee progress bars, rather than chasing tasks over email.

```
Navigation: Sidebar: Onboarding > Onboarding Dashboard (/onboarding)
```

5.1 Module Workflow: The Conversion Cascade

The cascade is triggered by the **Convert** action on an accepted offer and performs five things atomically. First, it creates the **employee record** with status probation and a generated employee code. Second, it opens a **preboarding case** starting at the first enabled stage after offer acceptance. Third, it generates the **onboarding tasks**: from active onboarding task templates when template generation is enabled and templates exist for the department, otherwise from the configured checklist phases - with due dates offset from the joining date and "System (auto-generated)" recorded as the assigner. Fourth, it sends **notifications** to IT (provisioning needed), Admin (workstation readiness), Finance (payroll setup) and HR (preboarding started), each linking back to the onboarding page. Fifth, it marks the application hired and decrements the job's

vacancy count.

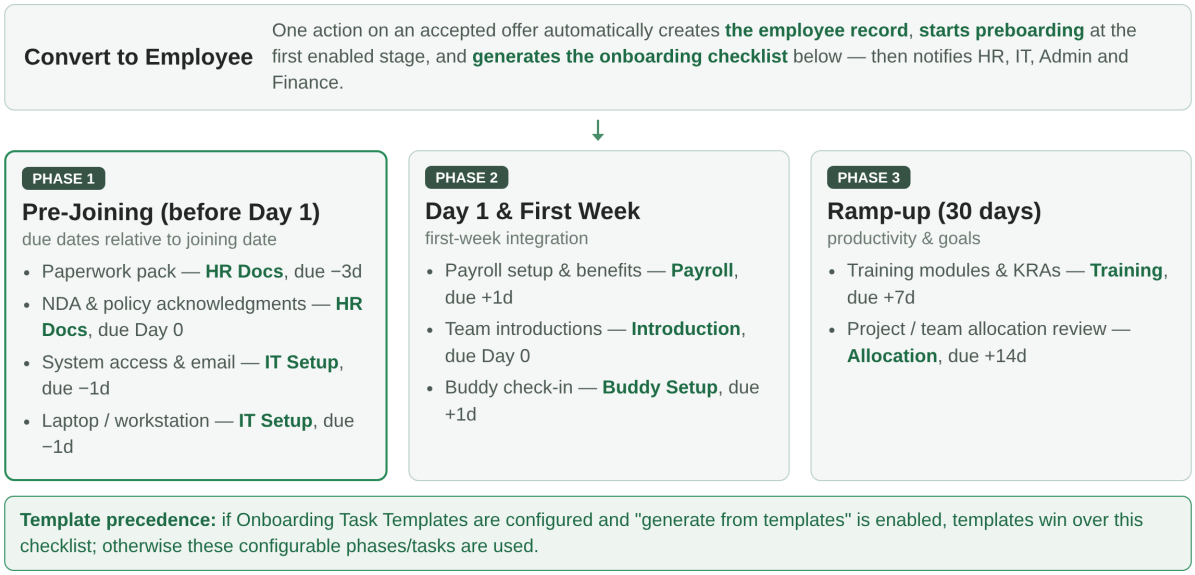


Figure 5-1: The onboarding cascade and the default three-phase checklist with category and due-date offsets.

Because the cascade is a single transaction, a conversion either fully succeeds or leaves no partial state. If something looks wrong afterwards - for example a missing task group - check the template precedence rule in section 5.4 and the configuration in Chapter 6.4 before creating tasks by hand, since hand-made duplicates are the most common cause of double-booked orientation sessions.

5.2 The Onboarding Screen

```
Navigation: Onboarding > /onboarding
```

The dashboard summarises the workload in four cards - **Total Tasks**, **Pending**, **In Progress** and **Completed** - above the checklist table. The table columns are **Employee, Task, Category, Due Date, Status, Notes** and **Actions**; rows can carry a Buddy chip, a "from: template" chip when generated from a template, and a preboarding origin reference. Filters cover the ten task categories (General, Documentation, IT Setup, Training, Compliance, HR Docs, Introduction, Buddy Setup, Payroll Setup, Project Allocation) and the four task statuses (Pending, In Progress, Completed, Skipped). The **Onboarding Progress** panel underneath aggregates per-employee completion: new hires, average completion percentage, overdue tasks and the number of employees fully onboarded, each with a progress bar and the next due task.

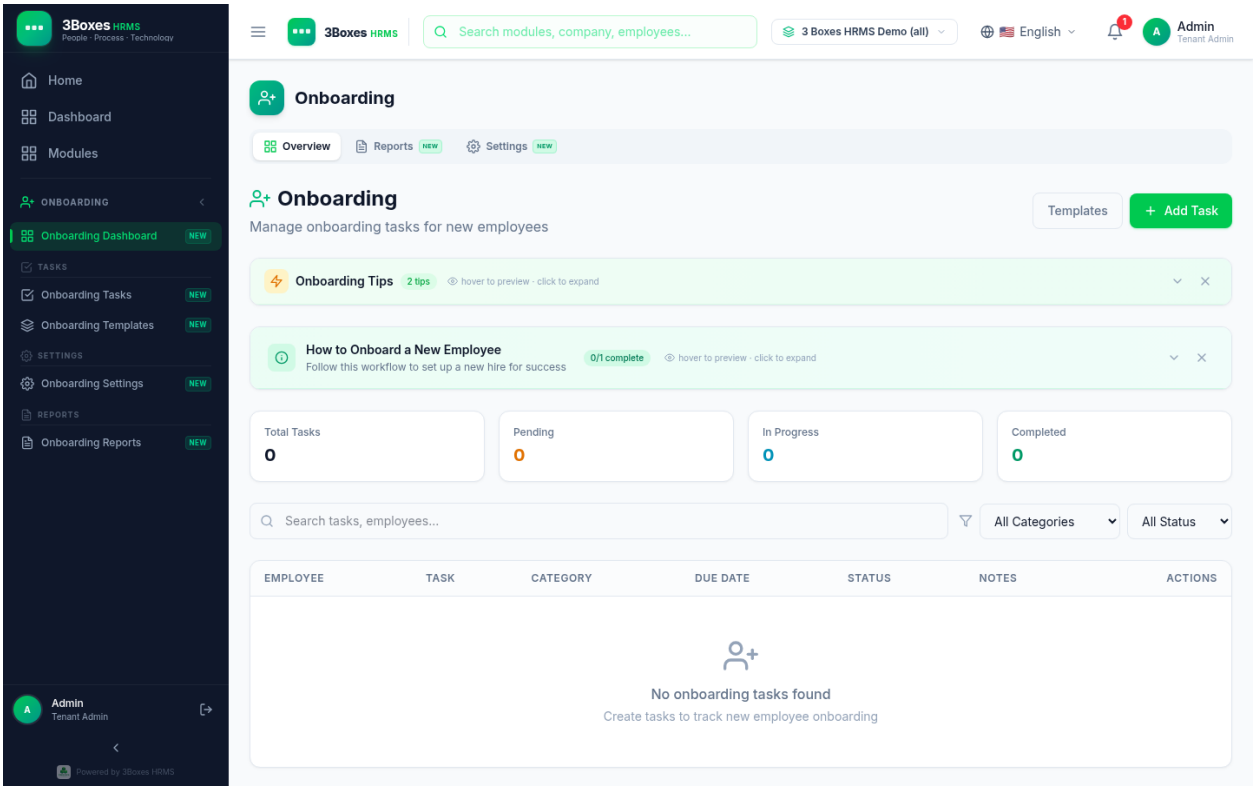


Figure 5-2: Onboarding dashboard - summary cards, filters and checklist table (demo tenant shown before its first conversion, hence the empty state).

SOP - Run onboarding for a new hire

1. Convert the accepted offer on **/offers** (see Chapter 3.5). The employee, preboarding case and checklist appear immediately.
2. Open **/onboarding** and filter by the new employee to review the generated tasks and their due dates.
3. Assign owners where needed by editing a task (Mentor / Check-in Owner, Priority, Training Module and KRA fields are available).
4. As work completes, click **Mark Complete** in the row's Actions column; the progress panel updates instantly.
5. Watch the Onboarding Progress panel daily during the first week - overdue tasks and stalled employees are visible at a glance.
6. After the ramp-up tasks (+7d training and KRAs, +14d allocation review) complete, the employee shows as fully onboarded.

5.3 Creating and Editing Tasks Manually

Any task can be added by hand with **Add Task**: choose the Employee, enter the Task description, pick one of the ten Categories, set a Due Date and optionally Notes, Priority, Training Module, KRA and Mentor / Check-in Owner. Manual tasks are the right tool for exceptional cases - a visa appointment, an extra compliance training for one region - while repeating structure belongs in templates or configuration so the next hire benefits automatically. Editing follows the same form; Status is editable only on existing tasks.

5.4 Task Templates and the Precedence Rule

```
Navigation: Onboarding > Onboarding Templates (/onboarding/templates)
```

Task templates are reusable checklist rows with a **Template Name**, **Task**, **Category**, **Due Offset** in days from joining, and optional role and department scoping, plus an active flag. When the configuration option **"Also generate from Onboarding Task Templates"** is enabled and at least one active template matches the new hire's department, **templates take precedence** over the configured checklist phases for that hire. In practice this means a department that maintains its own templates gets exactly those tasks, while everyone else receives the standard configured checklist - one system, two levels of customisation, no duplicate task sets.

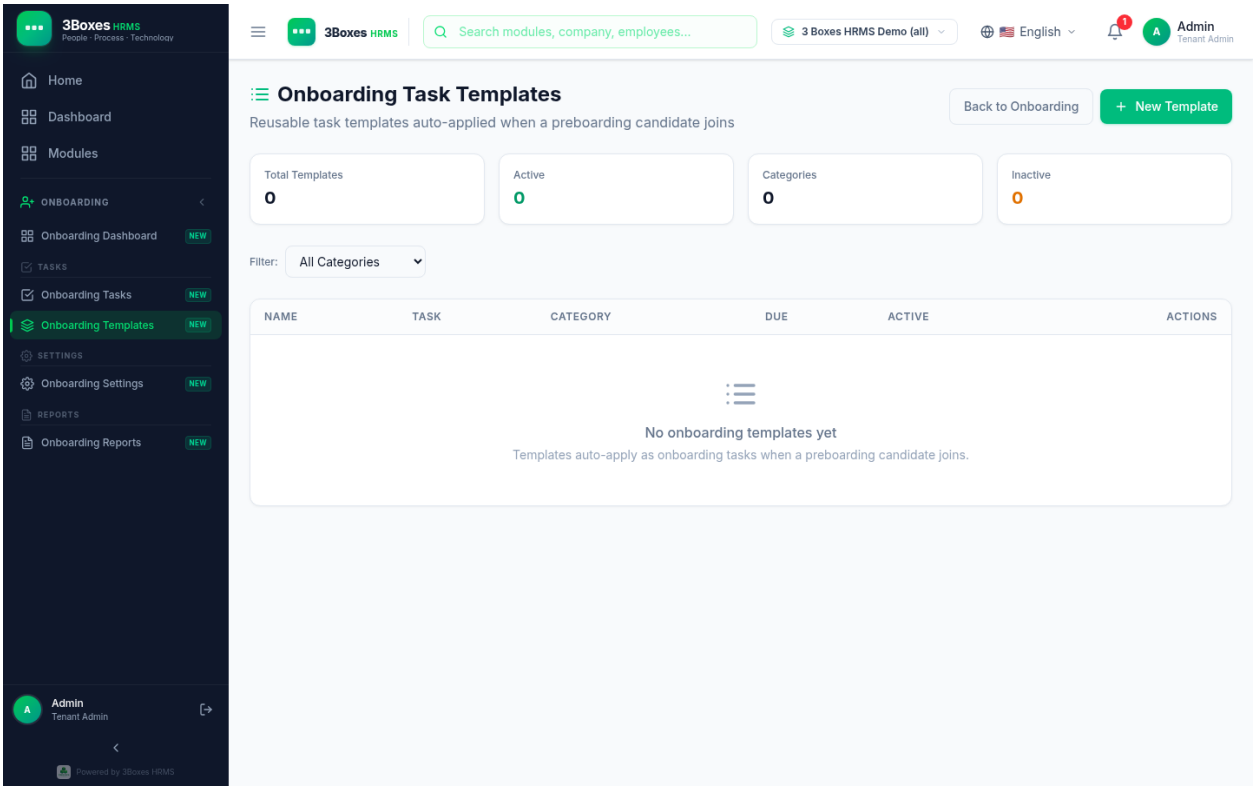


Figure 5-3: Onboarding Task Templates - reusable, department-scoped checklist rows that override the default checklist when enabled.

6. Workflow Configuration (Admin Guide)

Workflow Configuration is the single admin page that shapes all three modules. It has three tabs - **Recruitment Pipeline**, **Preboarding Stages** and **Onboarding Checklist** - and every change saved here applies to the whole tenant immediately: the pipeline table and dashboard chart, the preboarding ladder and the conversion checklist all read the saved configuration live. A yellow dot on a tab marks that the tab has been customised away from system defaults. Access is restricted to the management roles listed in 6.1; everyone else sees a permission notice.

```
Navigation: Recruitment > Workflow Configuration (/recruitment/workflow-config)
```

6.1 Access and How Configuration Resolves

Users with the roles **tenant_admin, admin, hr_admin, company_hr_admin or super_admin** can open the editor and save; the API enforces the same list, so the UI gate is a convenience rather than the security boundary. A super_admin must scope a save to a specific company. Configuration resolves in a clear order: a **company-scoped** saved configuration wins, then the **tenant-wide** one, and if neither exists the **built-in defaults** apply. Saved JSON is validated on every read; if a saved configuration is ever invalid, the system silently falls back to defaults rather than breaking the hiring flow. Merging is key-based, so a saved configuration that omits a stage leaves that stage at its default.

6.2 Tab 1: Recruitment Pipeline and Offer Approval Chain

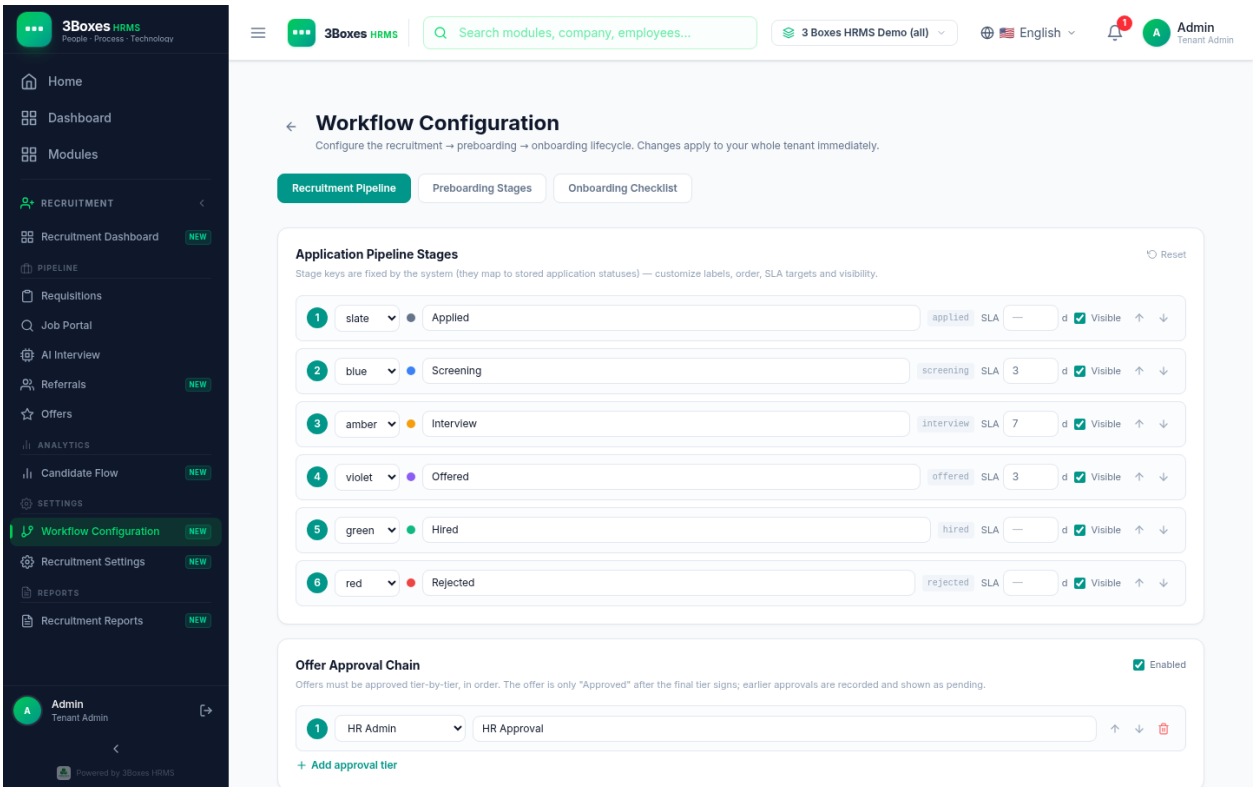


Figure 6-1: Workflow Configuration, Recruitment Pipeline tab - stage editor and the Offer Approval Chain.

Application Pipeline Stages

The six pipeline stages are listed with fixed keys and editable presentation. For each stage you can set the **colour** (slate, blue, amber, violet, green, red, cyan or pink), the **label** shown across the UI, the **SLA** target in days (0-365, blank for none), a **Visible** checkbox that hides the stage from pipeline views without changing stored data, and the **order** with the move up / move down arrows. Stage keys themselves cannot be added, deleted or renamed - they map to stored application statuses, which is what keeps historical data intact.

Offer Approval Chain

The chain is enabled with the **Enabled** checkbox and consists of ordered approval tiers. Each tier has an **approver type** - Reporting Manager, Department Head, HR Admin, Tenant Admin, Finance or Specific User - plus, for the Specific User type, a user picker, and a free-text **label** such as "HR Approval". Tiers can be added, reordered and deleted. The semantics matter: the offer must be approved **tier by tier, in order**, and it is only "Approved" after the final tier signs - earlier signatures are recorded and shown as pending. Leaving the tier list empty while the chain is disabled allows any admin-level role to approve, which suits small teams.

> **Rollout tip**
>
> After changing the chain, test it with a draft offer before relying on it: create an offer, Advance it, and confirm the first tier's approver sees the pending state. Tier rules apply to newly recorded approvals immediately.

6.3 Tab 2: Preboarding Stages

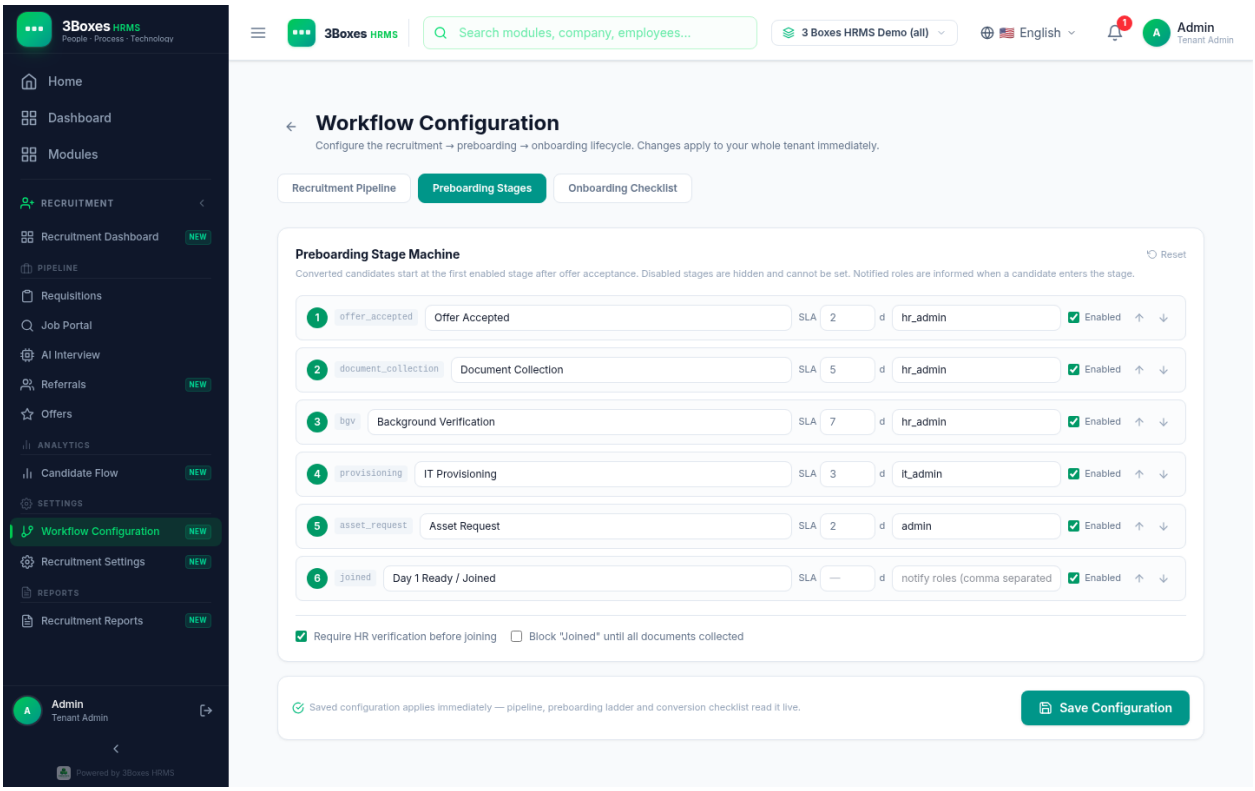


Figure 6-2: Workflow Configuration, Preboarding Stages tab - the stage machine with SLAs, notify roles and joining gates.

Each preboarding stage row exposes the fixed key chip, an editable **label**, an **SLA** in days, a **notify roles** field (comma-separated role keys such as hr_admin, it_admin, admin) and an **Enabled** checkbox, plus reorder arrows. Converted candidates start at the first enabled stage after offer acceptance, so disabling Document Collection, for example, makes such candidates enter at Background Verification - useful for contractors whose documents were collected at offer time. Below the ladder sit the two gates: **"Require HR verification before joining"** and **"Block \"Joined\" until all documents collected"**. Disabled stages are hidden in the UI and rejected by the API, so a shortened ladder is enforced, not merely suggested.

6.4 Tab 3: Onboarding Checklist

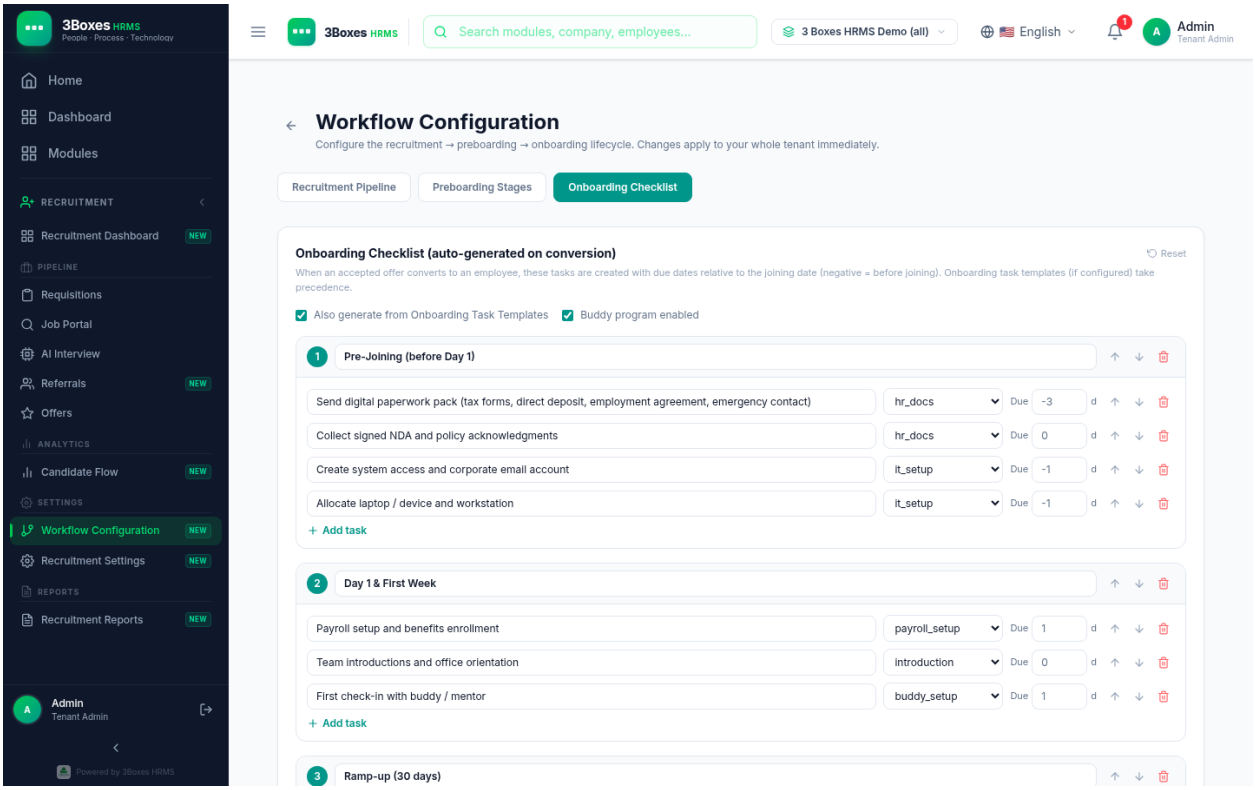


Figure 6-3: Workflow Configuration, Onboarding Checklist tab - phases with tasks, categories and due-date offsets.

The checklist is organised as ordered **phases**, each with a label and a set of task rows. Every task has a description, a **category** (general, it_setup, hr_docs, training, introduction, buddy_setup, payroll_setup, project_allocation) and a **Due** offset in days relative to the joining date, where negative numbers mean before joining (the default paperwork pack sits at -3 days) and positive numbers after it (ramp-up tasks at +7 and +14 days). Phases and tasks can be added, reordered and removed. Two checkboxes at the top control generation: **"Also generate from Onboarding Task Templates"** (templates win when they match, per Chapter 5.4) and **"Buddy program enabled"**.

6.5 Saving, Resetting and Safe Experimentation

Each tab ends in a save bar with the note that saved configuration applies immediately, and a **Save Configuration** button that performs the PUT to /api/recruitment/workflow-config. Every tab also has its own **Reset** action that restores the system defaults for that workflow after a confirmation prompt - your customisation for that tab is removed. Because reads are validated and fall back to defaults on error, experimentation is safe: a half-edited tab only takes effect when saved, and a bad save is reverted by Reset in seconds. Still, the recommended routine for significant changes is to announce them, save outside working hours, and verify on the dashboard charts as described in Chapter 3.2.

Workflow type	Configurable	Fixed by system
recruitment	Stage labels, colours, order, SLA, visibility; approval chain on/off, tiers (type, user, label, order)	Stage keys; that approval is sequential when enabled
preboarding	Stage labels, SLA, notify roles, enabled flags, order; both joining gates	Stage keys; forward-only advancing
onboarding	Phase labels and order, task text, category, due offset, add/remove; template generation toggle; buddy toggle	The ten task categories; that templates take precedence when matching

Table 6-1: Configuration surface per workflow type.

7. Roles and Permissions

The hiring modules use the platform's standard role model. Two capabilities matter most day to day: who can **manage workflow configuration**, and who can **approve offers** at each tier. Configuration management is restricted to tenant_admin, admin, hr_admin, company_hr_admin and super_admin - enforced by the API for both saving and resetting. Offer approval depends on the configured tiers: when a tier names a role type (HR Admin, Finance, and so on), any user holding that role qualifies; when a tier names a Specific User, only that user qualifies; when no chain is configured, only admin-level roles may approve.

Role	Recruitment	Preboarding / Onboarding	Workflow configuration
Super Admin	Full access across tenants (company scoping required to save config)	Full access	Can save, must target a company
Tenant Admin	Full access; fallback offer approver	Full access	Save and reset
HR Admin / Company HR Admin	Full ATS access; default tier-1 approver; HR Verified sign-off	Full access; advances stages; verifies documents	Save and reset
Manager / Department Head	Shortlist, interview feedback; can act as Reporting Manager or Department Head approval tier	Task completion for own reports	No
Finance	Approves CTC-sign-off tiers only	Payroll setup tasks	No
Employee (general)	No ATS access	Completes assigned onboarding tasks; may act as buddy	No

Table 7-1: Role capabilities across the three modules.

Two platform-level rules are worth remembering. First, all API routes verify the session token and the tenant database is resolved per tenant, so cross-tenant leakage is structurally prevented. Second, audit logging records the sensitive mutations - job posting creation, application status changes, offer status transitions (with tier signatures noted), and every workflow configuration update - giving auditors a complete trail without any extra effort from users.

8. Approval and Permission Matrix

The matrix below lists the seventeen actions that cover virtually all daily decision-making in the three modules, and which role may perform each. Where the offer approval chain is enabled, the tier configuration always wins: a tier of type Finance permits Finance users for that signature specifically, regardless of the generic "approve" column. Read "Admin-level" as tenant_admin, admin, hr_admin, company_hr_admin and super_admin.

#	Action	Who can do it
1	Create / edit / close job postings	Admin-level
2	Submit an application (internal form or careers site)	Anyone (public careers) / HR
3	Change application stage status	Admin-level; Edit Status on rows is admin-only
4	Shortlist / reject from candidate cards	Admin-level
5	Move candidate to talent pool	Admin-level
6	Run candidate shortlist analytics search	HR and managers
7	Schedule interview and record feedback	Admin-level and hiring managers
8	Create offer (draft)	Admin-level
9	Submit offer into approval (Advance)	Admin-level
10	Sign approval tier	The tier's role or specific user, in order
11	Send approved offer / copy candidate link	Admin-level
12	Record candidate acceptance or decline	System via candidate link; admin-level can update status
13	Convert accepted offer to employee	Admin-level
14	Advance preboarding stage	Admin-level (stage notify roles are informed)
15	Mark HR Verified	HR roles
16	Complete / edit onboarding tasks	Task owner, mentor, HR, admins
17	Save or reset workflow configuration	Admin-level (super_admin with company scope)

Table 8-1: Action-by-action permission matrix.

> **Reading rejections**
>
> A 403 on an offer action is almost always the tier gate, not a permission problem: the message names the exact tier and label required. Forward the offer to that approver rather than escalating.

9. Role Quick-Reference Cards

These four cards compress the daily routine of each key role into a few lines. They are intentionally terse - the detailed procedures live in Chapters 3 to 6. Print them or pin them in your team channel; they answer ninety percent of "how do I..." questions for new team members.

9.1 HR Administrator

- **Owns:** the whole ladder - postings to Day 1 - plus workflow configuration.
- **Morning:** dashboard cards (offers pending? overdue preboarding stages?), then clear blockers.
- **Core actions:** post jobs, move applications, create offers, advance preboarding stages, mark HR Verified, complete onboarding tasks.
- **Escalates:** tier approvers who have not signed; BGV vendor delays.
- **Configures:** stages, SLAs, approval tiers, checklist - then verifies on the dashboard.

9.2 Recruiter / Hiring Manager

- **Owns:** candidates from application to accepted offer.
- **Core actions:** shortlist via Analytics tab, schedule interviews, keep stage statuses truthful, create the offer draft, submit it for approval.
- **Remember:** you cannot approve your own offer through the chain - approvers sign in configured order.
- **After acceptance:** click Convert once, then confirm the checklist appeared on /onboarding.

9.3 Approver (Tier signatory)

- **Owns:** one signature in the offer chain.
- **Sees:** "Offer Pending Approval" notification linking to /offers.
- **Does:** review salary, position and joining date; click Advance once - the system records your tier.
- **If blocked:** the message names the tier that must sign before yours; wait or coordinate, do not retry.

9.4 IT / Admin / Finance support functions

- **Owns:** the provisioning, asset and payroll tasks that preboarding and onboarding assign to them.
- **Triggered by:** stage notifications (IT Provisioning, Asset Request) and conversion notifications (Payroll Setup Required).

- **Does:** complete the assigned onboarding task rows; keep the preboarding stage SLA in mind (3d provisioning, 2d assets by default).
- **Escalates:** missing information to HR via the task notes field, not email.

10. FAQ and Troubleshooting

The answers below reflect the enforced system behaviour, not conventions. Where a behaviour is configurable, the answer says so and points to Chapter 6.

10.1 Why is my offer stuck at "Pending Approval"?

The offer remains pending until **every configured tier** has signed, in order. Open the offer and check the approval trail: the first tier without a signature is the blocker, and its type or named user tells you exactly who to nudge. Clicking Advance as anyone else returns the 403 tier message. This is the sequential gate working as designed.

10.2 Who can approve if no tiers are configured?

If the chain is disabled or the tier list is empty, only admin-level roles can approve an offer - a deliberate single-signature fallback for small teams. Add tiers in Workflow Configuration, tab 1, when you want a real chain.

10.3 Can I rename or add pipeline stages?

You can rename labels, recolour, reorder, set SLAs and hide stages, but the six stage **keys** are fixed because application histories store them. A hidden stage (Visible unchecked) still exists for data purposes; new applications simply do not show it in pipeline views.

10.4 Why can't I set a preboarding candidate to a stage I removed?

Disabled stages are rejected by the API with a validation error - not just hidden in the UI. This guarantees the ladder your team sees is the ladder the system enforces. Re-enable the stage in tab 2 if you genuinely need it back.

10.5 A converted candidate has no onboarding tasks - why?

Two usual causes. First, template precedence: if "Also generate from Onboarding Task Templates" is enabled and a department-scoped template set matches, those templates replaced the default checklist - possibly with zero tasks if the matched templates are empty or inactive. Second, the configuration's phases may have been emptied. Check tab 3 and the templates page, then create the missing tasks once in configuration so future hires inherit them.

10.6 Where do due dates on generated tasks come from?

From the joining date plus each task's **Due** offset. Negative offsets land before joining (paperwork at -3 days), zero on Day 1, positive after (training +7, allocation review +14). Changing the joining date on the offer before conversion shifts the whole schedule; after conversion, edit task due dates directly.

10.7 What does an SLA number on a stage actually do?

It records a service target in days for that stage. The system surfaces stage ages and trends on dashboards and reports so breaches are visible; it does not auto-reject or auto-escalate. Treat SLA fields as your operational contract with the team, reviewed in the recruitment reports.

10.8 Why does the pipeline chart show my custom stage names?

The dashboard builds its pipeline chart from the **enabled configured stages**, so label and order changes appear immediately after saving. It is also the quickest smoke test that a configuration save worked.

10.9 Can two candidates share one preboarding stage order differently?

No - the ladder is global per tenant (or company scope). Different joins happen naturally: a candidate entering at Document Collection and another at Background Verification, depending on which stages were enabled at conversion time. To change an individual's position, advance or edit that candidate's stage.

10.10 What happens to the job's vacancy count after conversion?

The cascade decrements the posting's vacancies as part of conversion, keeping Open Positions honest. If the number looks wrong, check for duplicate applications marked hired on the same posting.

10.11 A candidate declined after preboarding started - now what?

Set the preboarding candidate to Cancelled from the preboarding page and reject or withdraw the offer record for the audit trail. Generated employee records and tasks should be cleaned up with HR review before Day 1 reporting is affected.

10.12 Who receives preboarding stage notifications?

The roles listed in each stage's **notify roles** field - by default hr_admin on the first three stages, it_admin on IT Provisioning and admin on Asset Request. Adjust the field per stage in tab 2; changes apply to future entries immediately.

11. Glossary

Terms are listed alphabetically. Keys in fixed-width style are system values users may encounter in filters, URLs or exports.

Term	Meaning
Advance (offer)	The Workflow-column button that moves an offer to its next status; while tiers are unsigned it records one tier signature.
Approval tier	One ordered signature step in the offer approval chain, bound to a role type or a specific user.
BGV	Background verification - the vendor-run check tracked in the BGV Tracking tab (statuses: Pending, In Progress, Completed, Failed).
Buddy program	Optional onboarding feature pairing the new hire with a buddy; adds buddy_setup tasks and a Buddy chip on task rows.
Cascade (conversion)	The single transaction behind Convert: employee record, preboarding case, generated checklist, notifications, hired status and vacancy decrement.
Category (task)	One of ten fixed onboarding task categories: general, it_setup, hr_docs, training, introduction, buddy_setup, payroll_setup, project_allocation (plus Documentation and Compliance in filters).
Company-scoped config	A workflow configuration saved for one company, which overrides the tenant-wide configuration and defaults.
Convert	The button on an accepted offer that runs the cascade.
Day 1 Ready	The final preboarding stage (key: joined), gated by HR verification and, optionally, complete documents.
Due offset	Days relative to the joining date used to schedule generated onboarding tasks; negative means before joining.
HR Verified	HR's confirmation toggle on a preboarding candidate, required before joining when the gate is enabled.
Onboarding progress	The per-employee completion panel (new hires, average completion, overdue tasks, fully onboarded).
Pending Approval	Offer state while approval tiers remain unsigned.
Pipeline stage key	Fixed stored value for an application stage (applied, screening, interview, offered, hired, rejected); labels are configurable.
Preboarding stage machine	The forward-only ladder of configured stages a converted candidate walks from offer acceptance to Day 1.
Requisition	The approved hiring request that precedes a job posting.
SLA (stage)	Configured service-target days for a pipeline or preboarding stage, used for reporting and dashboards.

Term	Meaning
Stage ladder	The visual bar on /preboarding showing configured stages with live candidate counts.
Talent pool	Holding status for strong candidates without an active match, instead of rejection.
Template precedence	The rule that matching onboarding task templates replace the configured checklist for a hire when template generation is enabled.
Tenant	Your organisation's isolated workspace; workflow configuration is tenant-wide unless company-scoped.
Tier order	The strict sequence in which offer approval tiers must sign; enforced by the API with a 403 on out-of-order attempts.
Time-to-hire	Dashboard metric averaging days from application to hire.
Workflow Configuration	The admin editor at /recruitment/workflow-config with three tabs shaping all three modules.
Workflow type	One of the three configurable workflows: recruitment, preboarding, onboarding.

Table 11-1: Glossary of module terminology.